

« Perhaps God wanted me to be in the World Cup-winning team »

AXAR PATEL

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When a left quadricep injury ruled Axar Patel out of India's ODI World Cup squad last year, uncertainty clouded his future.

However, he did not lose hope. Relying on his vast experience, Axar remained positive and dedicated himself to rigorous training during his rehabilitation at the National Cricket Academy.

Focussing on building mental toughness, Axar regained his form during the home series against Afghanistan and followed this up with a commendable IPL season for the Delhi Capitals. Despite the batter-friendly conditions and rules, Axar managed to stifle the opposition, claiming 11 wickets and scoring 235 runs.

He carried this newfound confidence into the T20 World Cup, emerging as a pivotal player for the Indian team, which ultimately clinched the title. Axar bowled economical overs, took a stunning catch against Australia near the

boundary, and contributed significantly with the bat. His crucial partnership with Virat Kohli in the final against South Africa was instrumental in India's victory.

The left-arm spin-bowling all-rounder, managed by JSW Sports, shared his journey in the T20 World Cup with *Sportstar*, highlighting how he thrives in a competitive environment and cherishes the challenges that come with it.

From missing out on an ODI World Cup spot last year to being a key member of India's T20 World

Cup-winning side. How would you look back on your journey over the last one year?

It was quite an emotional roller-coaster. I missed the ODI World Cup [in India] last year due to injury and found myself reflecting on missed opportunities from the past. Dealing with setbacks was nothing new, so I focussed on preparing for future opportunities. My sole focus was on earning a spot back on the Indian team. I underwent rehabilitation at the National Cricket Academy [in Bengaluru], made adjustments to my batting and



When you bat with the security of a strong lower-middle order, you can play with more freedom than when batting at No. 7 or No. 8. In those positions, you need to take calculated risks.